

ENGLISH LANGUAGE PAPER 4

PART A Group Interaction

This article appeared in a newspaper in Canada:

Growing use of animals in helping the sick

Animal-assisted therapy was once rare and met with the objection that it would only make hospitals dirty. It is, however, increasingly popular in hospitals, according to an Ontario doctor.

From watching goldfish swim to having a dog, animal therapy is used to help people relax and give comfort. Many hospitals and homes for the elderly now have animal therapy programs in place.

"People think it works and like the idea of it, so they do it," explains Maggie O'Haire, a doctor in Ontario University.

One challenge as the practice has become more widespread has been explaining how exactly it works. "Positive changes from animal-assisted contact are varied and there is no single way that has yet been identified," says O'Haire.

There are a number of theories, however. One is that humans have always enjoyed connecting with other living things. Another is the social support theory – the idea that therapy animals provide a form of simple support.

In the past ten years, animal-assisted therapy has greatly expanded. Today, programs exist that provide animals who assist with physical therapy, help tutor children in reading and provide comfort in different places such as disaster zones and university campuses.

While research on the subject still has a long way to go, recently studies have shown that having a pet around can lower blood pressure, and the American Heart Association has stated that owning a dog may even lower the risk of heart disease.

Your school principal is interested in keeping pets at the school as he believes that animal therapy is good for students. He has asked you to discuss the idea. You may want to talk about:

- the advantages and disadvantages of animal therapy
- what types of animal would be most suitable for a school
- how the animals could be looked after and help the students
- anything else you think is important

PART B Individual Response

1. Do you like playing with animals?
2. Would you like your school to have a pet?
3. Do you think students would be good at looking after a school pet?
4. Is Hong Kong a suitable place for animal therapy?
5. Should animals be allowed into hospitals?
6. What animals are suitable for the elderly?
7. What can looking after a pet teach people?
8. How does a pet provide emotional support for people?